

The Best Places to Eat Ramen

Yatai by the river inexpensive

Festooned with lights and constantly buzzing with diners, the *yatai* stands beside the Nakasu River in the center of the city offer one of the world's greatest low-cost dining experiences. The lines to sample their hot, steaming bowls of gut-busting ramen can often be daunting, but people eat quickly here and you can always enjoy a beer while you wait. On the menu are not just magnificent examples of the ramen chef's art but also tempura, other noodle dishes, grilled fish, *yakitori*, and slow-cooked *oden*. *Oden* is a kind of Japanese *pot au feu* made with tofu, boiled eggs, *daikon* (a kind of white radish), *konnyaku* (a solid jelly made from a root vegetable), and *kamaboko* (colorful steamed fish-paste cakes), all bobbing in an everlasting savory brown liquid topped off every morning. Unthinkably, the *yatai* of Fukuoka are under threat from a local authority determined to "clean up" its streets, so visit while you still can.

Nakasu (by the river in front of Canal City); open sunset–midnight daily

Also in Fukuoka

If you are looking for a more civilized environment in which to sample Hakata ramen, **Ichiran Ramen** (www.ichiran.co.jp/pc/hp/english; *inexpensive*), which opened in 1960, is a legend throughout Japan. Though it now has branches across the country, the original shop remains a place of pilgrimage for ramen fans. Each diner gets a questionnaire to fill in with which they can fine-tune their order, specifying the firmness of the noodles, the strength of the onion, the fattiness of the broth, and so on.

Also in Japan

In Tokyo, the **Ramen Jiro** (*inexpensive*) at 2-16-4 Mita, Minato-ku, is a legend: this grimy, rather forbidding place is famed for its mammoth bowls of "rustic" *tonkotsu* pork broth ramen, piled high with cabbage and the saltiest, fattiest pork. The chef at this Jiro – the original of a large chain – is one of a number of gruff, scarred ramen masters who have ascended to quasi-deity status, respected and feared like the feudal warriors of yore (albeit with their own pot-noodle ranges). Expect to line up around the block, whatever time of day, month, or season.

Around the World

Ramen has now conquered New York, with locals lapping up this quick, savory, filling dish in restaurants across Manhattan, but the most famous is **Ippudo** on Fourth Avenue (www.ippudony.com; *moderate*). Having transferred from Japan – where there are Ippudos up and down the land – this branch has scored a notable hit with its uncharacteristically (for a ramen joint) slick venue in the East Village. Lines start every day up to an hour before it opens, and keep on going until closing time.



Above Hakata ramen often includes *chashu* (simmered pork), *kikurage* (wood-ear mushrooms), and *karashi takana* (spicy pickled greens)

Left Cooks add ingredients for some made-to-order Hakata ramen at a night street stand, or *yatai*, beside the river in Fukuoka